

A Thin Veiled Night
The Palmerton Switch

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EXT. BLUE MOUNTAIN / "THE DEAD MOUNTAIN" - NIGHT (JANUARY 1985)

A hemp sled rope, wrapped twice around a red wool mitten, pulls tight. Snow falls straight down in fat flakes. No wind at all.

ANNIE SABOL (16) hauls a Flexible Flyer up a bare white slope. Riding it like a king: her brother DANNY SABOL (10), stocking cap, a shoelace around his neck.

Above them the mountain is snow over rock and burned stumps, not one tree standing. Below them, the yard lights of the zinc works turn the falling snow orange.

ANNIE (V.O.)

Everybody in Palmerton called it the dead mountain. The zinc smoke killed every tree on it before I was born. Under snow, though, it was the best hill in Carbon County.

DANNY

Faster, Annie. Mush.

ANNIE

Mom said take your brother. She didn't say carry him.

She keeps hauling. Her knees are soaked through two pairs of jeans.

EXT. UPPER RAIL YARD / ZINC WORKS - CONTINUOUS

Down the slope, twelve black tank cars stand in a line on the upper siding. White stencil on every belly: SULFURIC ACID.

ANNIE (V.O.)

My grandfather walked that siding thirty-one years as a switchman. He used to say a full acid car weighed more than a church and was meaner than the devil's cat if it ever got loose.

A low grinding. A coupler knocks, hollow, like a fist on a barn door.

The cars begin to roll. No engine. No brakeman. Nobody.

DANNY
Annie. The cars.

ANNIE
We're above the yard. We're fine.

DANNY
No. They're going.

Annie turns, rope still around her mitten. The string eases off the end of the siding, slow as a cow leaving a field, and tips onto the long grade toward town.

ANNIE
Somebody's moving them.

DANNY
Nobody's on them. Annie. Nobody's on them.

She counts with her lips. Twelve cars. Not one person.

INT. SABOL KITCHEN - DAY (FLASHBACK, 1977)

A church bulletin flipped over on oilcloth. A big man's pencil draws a long curving line. DZEDO (50s), switchman's cap on the chair back, a GIRL ANNIE (8) at his elbow.

DZEDO
Here's the upper yard. Grade runs down a mile, through the cut by the east plant, down to the crossing by the ballfield. Halfway, here. The Palmerton switch.

He draws a short stub line off the side, ending in a scribbled heap.

DZEDO (CONT'D)

Catch track. Runs up into cinders
tall as a house. A car breaks
loose up top, a man throws the
switch, sends her up the cinders.
She digs in. Town sleeps.

GIRL ANNIE

What if nobody's there?

DZEDO

Somebody's always there.

EXT. THE DEAD MOUNTAIN - NIGHT (PRESENT, 1985)

Far below, a horn sounds from the high school gym.
Headlights crawl down the hill roads toward the river.

ANNIE

The varsity game let out.
Everybody's going to be sitting at
that crossing.

DANNY

The switch.

Danny digs inside his coat and pulls up the shoelace. On
the end, a brass key swings in the orange light. Stamped on
the bow: LNE.

ANNIE (V.O.)

Dzedo gave him that key for
Christmas. Mom said it was a toy
now. Dzedo said a switch is never
a toy.

DANNY

They still lock it. Dzedo walks
down Sundays and checks.

Annie looks at the slope below the third fence post, where
the mountain drops off steep into a long white chute.

ANNIE

Get on. Lie flat. Hold the sides
and don't let go of the sides for
anything.

DANNY
Are we going to the switch?

ANNIE
We're going to the switch.

Danny lies belly down on the Flyer and grabs both rails.
Annie drops on top of him, takes the steering bar, digs in
her boot toes, and shoves.

EXT. THE ELEVATOR (STEEP CHUTE) - CONTINUOUS

They go over the lip. The world drops.

Runners hiss, then roar. Snow sprays up off the nose and
slaps Annie's face like thrown sand. Every buried rock
bangs up through the slats into her ribs. Danny yells under
her.

To their LEFT, through the snow, the tank cars race down
the grade beside them, black, huge, picking up speed with
every rail joint. The thunder comes up through the ground.

First fence post. Second. At the third the sled goes
airborne and slams down. Annie's teeth clack. Blood on her
lip.

She hauls the bar left, missing a burned stump by a foot.

The lead tank car pulls even with them. Then ahead.

DANNY
Annie, we're losing.

ANNIE
I know.

DANNY
Pray. Dzede says pray.

ANNIE

You pray. I'm steering.

DANNY

(face an inch off the snow,
loud)

Lord Jesus Christ, Son of God,
have mercy on us. Lord Jesus
Christ, Son of God, have mercy on
us.

Annie keeps her own mouth shut and steers.

ANNIE (V.O.)

I'd quit praying out loud around
eighth grade. Even then, with the
cars running away beside me, I was
embarrassed.

EXT. DRIFT ABOVE THE CUT - CONTINUOUS

The chute ends in a deep drift. The sled plows in, spins,
and pitches them both into powder to the waist.

Annie comes up spitting snow. Thirty yards down the bank,
beside the rail: THE PALMERTON SWITCH. A cast-iron stand
with a round red target on top. A long iron lever lying
flat along the ties, padlocked to the stand. The lock is
white with frost.

Up the grade, a quarter mile off, the lead car swings
around the curve out of the east plant cut, snow boiling
off its wheels.

EXT. THE PALMERTON SWITCH - CONTINUOUS

They half run, half fall down the bank and hit the ballast
together. Danny yanks the shoelace over his head so hard
his cap flies off.

Annie bites off her right mitten and spits it in the snow.
Bare fingers. She jams the key in the lock on the second
try and twists. It won't turn.

ANNIE

It's froze. It's frozen solid.

DANNY

Breathe on it. Dzede breathes on
it.

She bends and breathes on the lock, hot and hard. Twists.
Breathes again.

The rail beside her boots starts to SING. The lead car is
close enough now to read the white letters.

Danny puts his mittens over her bare hand and prays fast,
the words running into each other.

DANNY

Lord Jesus Christ Son of God have
mercy on us Lord Jesus Christ Son
of God...

Annie's fingers won't close anymore. She stops twisting.
Her forehead drops against the cold stand.

ANNIE

(out loud, mouth against the
lock)

Jesus. I need more time. Please. I
need more time than this.

SILENCE.

Every snowflake in the air STOPS. Millions of them, hanging
still as stars between Annie and the yard lights.

The roar of the cars stretches into ONE LONG LOW NOTE, the
way a church organ hangs on the final chord of a hymn.

Up the grade, a hundred yards off, the lead car sits frozen
in motion, snow spraying off its wheels and not falling,
like a photograph of a wave.

Danny kneels beside her with his mouth open on the word
"mercy." A flake sits on his eyelashes. He does not blink.

ANNIE

Danny?

No answer from him. Not a breath.

Down the track, from the town side, a YELLOW LIGHT comes swinging at hip height, passing through the hung snow without knocking a single flake loose.

Behind it walks THE LANTERN MAN. A head taller than the switch stand. Canvas railroad coat to the knees, buttoned up under his chin, short-brimmed cap. In one hand, an old kerosene lantern, red glass globe, wire handle, carried easy, like a lunch pail.

His boots crunch on the ballast. In all the held world, only his boots make a sound.

He stops across the stand from Annie and lifts the lantern so its light falls on the lock and on her raw hands.

He doesn't touch the lock. He doesn't touch her. His face over the lantern is kind the way a doctor is kind just before he sets a bone. He waits.

ANNIE (V.O.)

I knew right then he wasn't going to throw it for me. The light was for seeing by. The time was the time I asked for. The hands were mine.

Annie breathes on the lock in the lantern light. Her breath goes out warm and white and hangs in the air with the snow.

She turns the key. The lock gives with a little crack, like a knuckle.

She drags the shackle out of the hasp and drops the lock in the snow.

INT. SABOL BACKYARD - DAY (FLASHBACK, SUMMER 1977)

A practice switch lever Dzede has bolted to a railroad tie by the garden. Dzede stands behind Girl Annie, his big hands over her small ones on the handle.

DZEDO

Feet wide. Lift her up off the tie. Now lean your whole body across and walk her over. Don't fight her. Walk her.

The lever swings over in a half circle and lies down on the far side.

EXT. THE PALMERTON SWITCH - NIGHT (HELD TIME)

Annie, sixteen, grips the real lever in both bare hands. Feet wide in the ballast. She lifts.

It doesn't move. Frozen into the stand.

She sets her feet wider and lifts again with her legs and her back. The iron rips the skin off the inside of her palms where it sticks. She holds on.

ANNIE

(through her teeth)

Jesus. Jesus. Jesus.

The handle breaks loose. One inch. Six inches. All the way up. She gets her shoulder under it, leans her whole body across it, and WALKS IT OVER.

Ice cracks down in the points. At the rail the two long steel blades scrape across in the lantern light and close tight against the other rail.

On top of the stand the round target turns on its spindle. RED becomes GREEN.

Annie lays the lever down. Stands. Her palms are bleeding.

The Lantern Man looks at the green target, then at her. He lowers the lantern to his side.

THE LANTERN MAN
(far off, deep, like an
engine idling a mile away)
Good.

He turns and walks back toward town the way he came. The yellow light goes down the track through the hung snow, gets small, and goes out.

EXT. THE PALMERTON SWITCH - NIGHT (TIME RESUMES)

The snow FALLS, all of it at once. The organ note BREAKS into thunder.

DANNY
...mercy on us.

Danny blinks and grabs her coat.

The lead car comes off the grade straight at them, ROARING.

Annie throws herself and Danny backward into the drift. The car hits the points and swings RIGHT onto the catch track. Then the next car. Then the next. Twelve black acid cars buck and shriek off the main grade one after another and run uphill on the dead track.

EXT. CATCH TRACK / CINDER BANK - CONTINUOUS

The lead car buries its nose in the cinder bank like a plow. The string piles in behind it, coupler on coupler, a crash that shakes snow off the stand.

A black and white cloud of cinders and snow rolls up over the end of the track and settles.

The cars stop knocking, one at a time. Only a hiss now, hot brake shoes melting the falling snow.

Not one car tipped. Not one cracked.

EXT. THE PALMERTON SWITCH - MOMENTS LATER

Danny cries into Annie's coat.

DANNY
You stopped it. Annie, the snow
stopped. Did you see the snow stop?

ANNIE
I saw it.

DANNY
Did you see the man?

Annie doesn't answer. She holds him and looks down the track toward town.

On the ballast by the stand: her boot prints. Danny's. The open lock in the snow. No other prints. No big boots going toward town.

A plant WHISTLE starts blowing. Then the fire SIREN from the borough building.

EXT. THE PALMERTON SWITCH - LATER

Flashlight beams all over the grade. GUS REMALEY (50s), yard foreman, thermos-colored face, finds them on the switch stand. Annie's bare hands are stuffed in Danny's armpits for warmth.

Gus looks at the green target. The open lock. The key on the shoelace. The twelve cars in the cinders. He says a word their mother wouldn't allow in the house.

He pulls off his own gloves and works them onto Annie's hands.

GUS
Who threw this?

ANNIE
I did.

GUS

You threw this. Frozen. By
yourself.

ANNIE

Yes sir.

Gus doesn't believe her. He doesn't argue either.

ANNIE (V.O.)

The company said the afternoon
crew never set the handbrakes
right and the cold let the slack
run out. The Allentown paper ran a
little piece on page six. Nobody
ever asked me about the snow.

INT. SABOL KITCHEN / COLUMBIA AVENUE - NIGHT

A radio scanner crackles on the counter. DZEDO (70s),
undershirt, coffee, rosary looped over his wrist, sits at
the table. He has heard it all come over the scanner.

Annie and Danny come in with snow on their shoulders. Dzedo
looks at Annie's gloved hands and Danny's wet face. He
doesn't ask.

He gets up, fills a dishpan with cool water, peels off the
foreman's gloves, and sets her hands in the water one at a
time. He holds her wrists there.

DZEDO

You threw it.

ANNIE

Yes.

DZEDO

Handle was froze.

ANNIE

Yes.

He keeps his hands on her wrists. Tips his head toward the
ceiling, where their mother is asleep. Lowers his voice.

DZEDO

Did he hold the lantern for you?

Annie looks up at him.

DZEDO (CONT'D)

February, nineteen fifty-one. Coal car off the upper yard. Me, twenty-two, at that same switch with my hands froze to it. Big fellow. Red globe on the lantern. He held it so I could see the lock.

He pats the back of her hand in the water, gently, the way he pats the dog.

DZEDO (CONT'D)

He doesn't throw it for you. You know that now.

ANNIE

I know.

EXT. BLUE MOUNTAIN - DAY (PRESENT DAY, SUMMER)

The same slope, GREEN now. Grass, little birches, sumac. A woman walks a dog up a trail with binoculars around her neck.

ANNIE (V.O.)

The zinc company's been gone a long time. The government spent twenty years spreading seed and lime on the dead mountain, and it came back. The catch track's gone. The switch stand's gone. Dzede's been gone since ninety-seven. Danny's a deacon now. He still wears that key on a shoelace on Sundays.

INT. ANNIE'S KITCHEN / PALMERTON HILL - NIGHT (PRESENT DAY)

ANNIE (57) at the window with a cup of coffee. A GRANDDAUGHTER (7) tugs her sleeve. Annie turns her palm up. White scars run across the inside of it.

ANNIE

That's from the night I asked for
more time. And I got it.

GRANDDAUGHTER

How much time?

ANNIE

Enough.

Outside, snow begins to fall. Straight down. No wind.

ANNIE (V.O.)

I pray out loud now. Grocery
store, car, wherever. I never told
them the snow stopped. I keep that
one.

She watches the green mountain go white in the dark.

ANNIE (V.O.)

On nights like this I still stand
here and watch for a yellow light
coming down out of the dark toward
town. It never has. I still look.

FADE OUT.